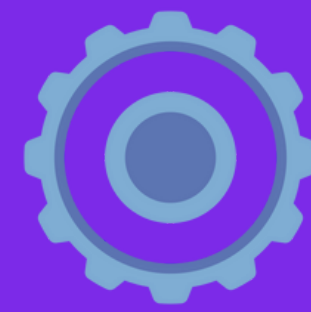


Prompt Engineering for Enterprise AI Agents (Best Practices)

Prompt Engineering in Foundry

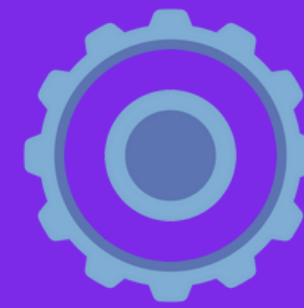


In Foundry, a prompt is **not just instructions**.
It's a **contract** between you and the agent.

That contract defines:

- **What the agent is allowed to do**
- **Where truth comes from**
- **How tools are used**
- **What happens when information is missing**

Microsoft strongly recommends **explicit, restrictive, and role-based prompts** for enterprise agents.



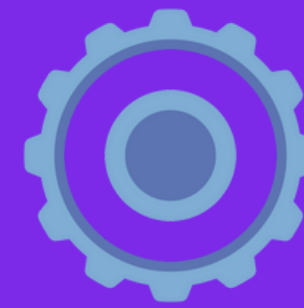
Core principle #1: Role clarity

✗ Vague Prompt (Not Recommended)

“You are a helpful assistant.”

✓ Enterprise-Grade Prompt (Recommended)

“You are the Support Dispatcher.
Your role is to analyze the user’s query and route it to one of three specialized agents: Billing, Shipping, or Technical.
If the user mentions ‘money’ or ‘refund’, route to Billing.
Never give medical or legal advice.
Format your output as a JSON object with the keys ‘target_agent’ and ‘summary’.”

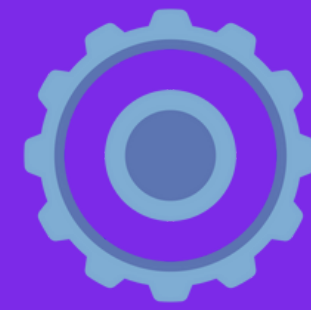


Core principle #2: Grounding over general knowledge

✓ Grounding Prompt (Recommended)

“You MUST use the File Search tool as the sole source of truth when answering questions related to product usage, manuals, or policies.

If the required information is not found, respond politely that the information is unavailable.”



Core principle #3: Tool invocation guidance

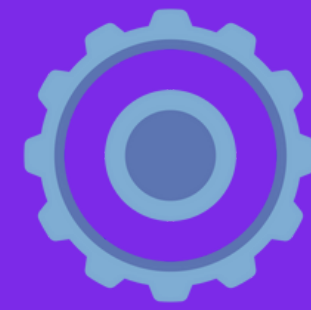
✗ Bad approach

“Use tools when needed.”

✓ Good approach

“If the user’s question involves vehicle operation, warnings, or maintenance, you **MUST** call the File Search tool first.”

Prompt Engineering in Foundry



Core principle #1: Role clarity

Core principle #2: Grounding over general knowledge

Core principle #3: Tool invocation guidance

Best Practices

1. Be explicit, even if it feels repetitive
2. Separate grounding from guardrails
3. Define failure behavior

Common Pitfalls

1. Overly permissive prompts
2. Mixing responsibilities
3. Assuming the model remembers constraints

Think in layers:

#1: Role and responsibility

#2: Grounding rules

#3: Tool usage rules

#4: Output format